21

Confident policymakers work in the open

In public policy, we don't just dine with friends, we must also sup with fiends.

Ashok Desai

There is a long tradition of secrecy in public policy in India. Too often, in India, a reform is pushed through as a sudden *fait accompli* upon the losers. As the complexity of the economy has grown, and as Indian democracy has matured, it is increasingly unwise to maintain this level of secrecy.

Secrecy harms planning and execution

Exposing early drafts to the persons who have a lot at stake may often yield improvements in the work. Particularly when we have low state capacity, the most well-meaning reform is often marred by technical mistakes in the execution. A more open policy process catches more errors and it improves the resulting work.

As an example, most draft laws in India are faulty owing to gaps in capabilities for drafting law in government organizations and in their supporting law firms. A thorough and genuine process of consultation will find mistakes.

One of the reasons why the demonetization decision suffered from difficulties of policy design and implementation was the secrecy in which it was surrounded. The areas of Indian public policy which are shrouded in secrecy (military, intelligence, trading in the RBI treasury) may have the biggest flaws.